Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology

AI-Based Social Integration and Inclusion Platform for University Freshers

Project Management Tool Report

IT4010 - Research Project

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1. Introduction

Effective project management is essential for ensuring the successful completion of group-based academic work. In this research project, a variety of project management tools were employed to plan, organize, communicate, and track progress throughout the entire project lifecycle. These tools supported multiple aspects of project execution, including task management, scheduling, collaboration, document sharing, and communication, which collectively enhanced the efficiency and organization of the team.

ClickUp was used as the primary tool for task management, enabling the team to assign responsibilities, set deadlines, and monitor progress in real time. Smartsheet complemented this by providing a detailed Gantt chart, which offered a visual timeline of the research process, helping to schedule tasks, identify dependencies, and ensure timely completion of milestones. For collaboration and content creation, tools like GitHub and Canva were utilized. GitHub allowed for version control and secure sharing of project files, while Canva facilitated the creation of visually appealing presentations and infographics to communicate research findings effectively.

Communication within the team was maintained through WhatsApp for instant messaging and calls, allowing quick clarification of questions and updates. Google Drive acted as a central repository for file storage and sharing, while Microsoft Teams and Google Docs enabled real-time collaboration, virtual meetings, and simultaneous document editing.

By integrating these tools, the team achieved better coordination, smoother communication, and more efficient task management. This structured approach not only minimized delays and confusion but also promoted accountability and active participation among team members, ultimately contributing to the successful and timely completion of the group research project.

2. Project Management Tools

2.1 ClickUp

ClickUp was used as the primary project management tool to organize, track, and manage the group research project efficiently. It provided a centralized platform for coordinating tasks, monitoring progress, and maintaining alignment with project objectives. The project structure was organized using task lists such as “To Do,” “In Progress,” and “Completed,” allowing clear visualization of workflow stages. Each task was assigned to specific team members with defined deadlines, priorities, and detailed descriptions. This ensured clarity of responsibilities and improved accountability across the team. The Kanban-style board view made it easy to track task status and overall project progress briefly. Communication was enhanced through built-in features such as task comments and mentions. Discussions, updates, and feedback were linked to relevant tasks, reducing confusion and ensuring that all information remained organized within a single platform. This minimized reliance on external communication tools and improved documentation of project-related interactions.

ClickUp also supported effective progress tracking by allowing deadlines to be monitored and tasks to be updated in real time. This was particularly useful for managing distinct phases of the research project and ensuring timely completion of deliverables. Additionally, the option to attach files and resources to tasks enabled easy access to important documents. Overall, ClickUp contributed to improved coordination, better time management, and a more structured workflow, supporting the successful execution of the research project. Figure 2.1 represents ClickUp board view and figure 2.2 depicts ClickUp members that are in the group.

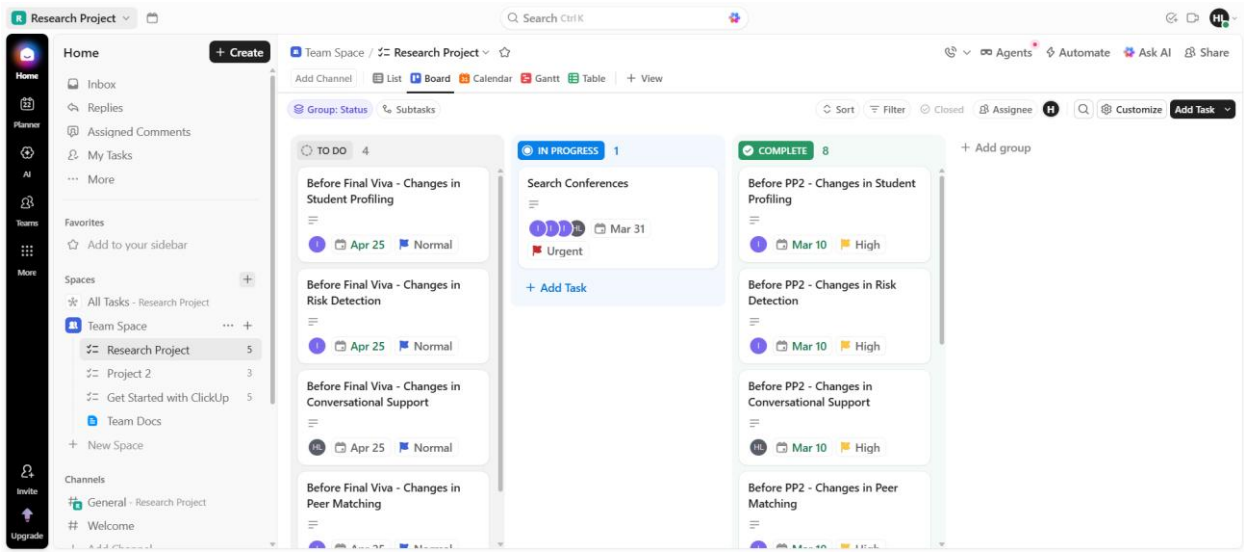

Figure 2.1: ClickUp Board View

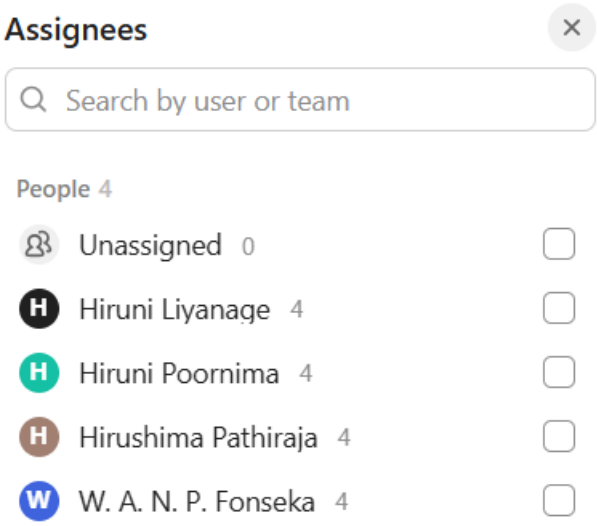

Figure 2.2: ClickUp Members

2.2 Smartsheet

Smartsheet was used to create and manage the Gantt chart for the full duration of the research project. It provided a structured and timeline-based view of all project activities, enabling effective planning and scheduling from the initial phase to final completion. The Gantt chart in Smartsheet was used to define all key tasks, milestones, and dependencies across the project timeline. Each activity was assigned a start date, end date, and duration, ensuring a clear understanding of the project schedule. Task dependencies were particularly useful in identifying the sequence of activities, allowing better coordination, and reducing the risk of delays. Smartsheet also enabled easy visualization of the entire project timeline in a single view. This made it simple to track progress, identify overlapping tasks, and adjust schedules when necessary. Any updates made to tasks were automatically reflected in the Gantt chart, ensuring that the timeline remained accurate and up to date throughout the research period.

Collaboration was supported through shared access, allowing all team members to view the project schedule and stay informed about deadlines and milestones. This improved transparency and helped maintain alignment with project goals. Overall, the use of Smartsheet for Gantt chart creation enhanced planning accuracy, improved time management, and provided a clear roadmap for the successful completion of the research project. Figure 2.3 shows Smartsheet Gantt chart Gantt view and figure 2.4 represents Smartsheet Gantt chart timeline view which shows the timeline of the project.

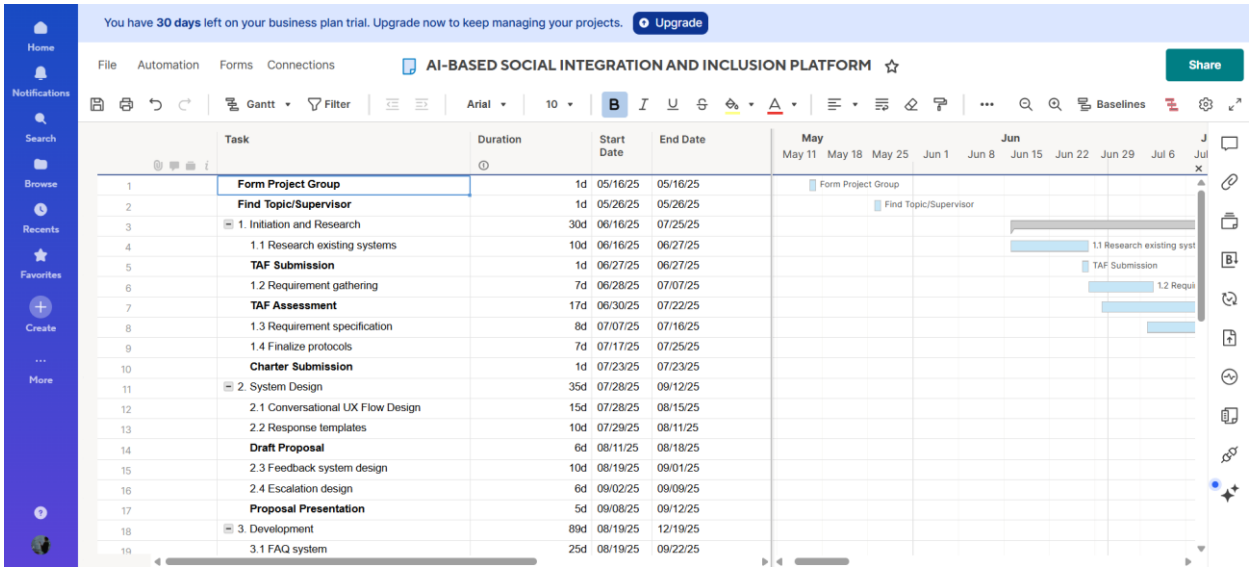

Figure 2.3: Smartsheet Gantt Chart Gantt View

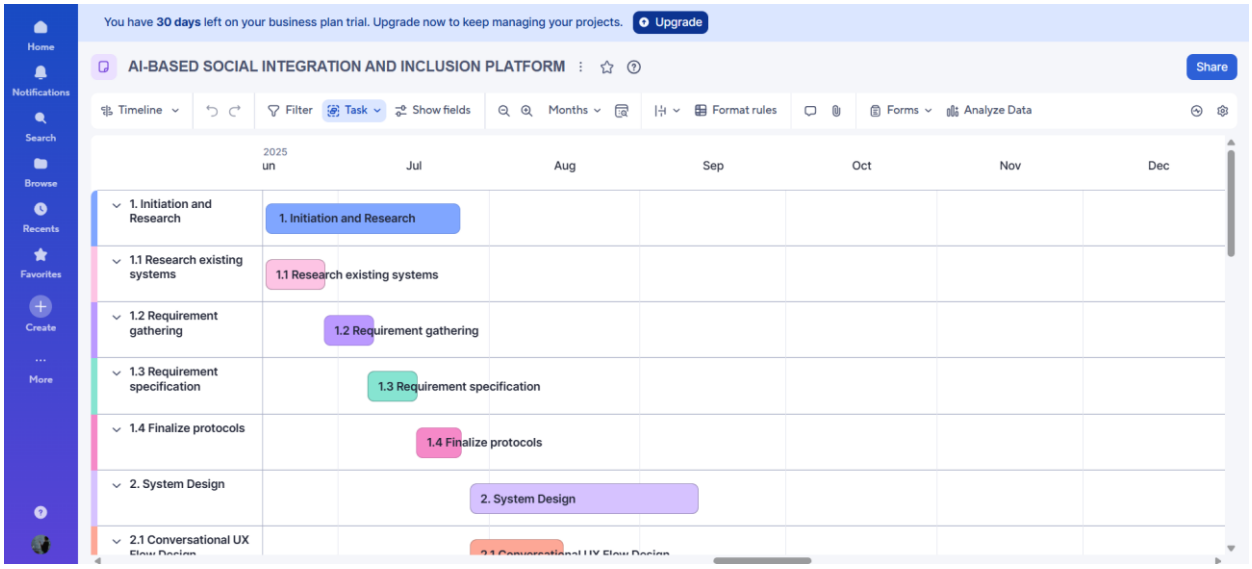

Figure 2.4: Smartsheet Gantt Chart Timeline View

2.3 GitHub

GitHub is a cloud-based platform built around the distributed version control system, Git. It serves as a central repository for code, enabling collaborative software development by allowing multiple contributors to work on the same project simultaneously while maintaining a complete history of changes.

In our project, GitHub served as the essential platform for integrating each member's components into a cohesive system. The core of our workflow was built around branching and pull requests. Each team member developed their assigned component on a separate feature branch, which allowed for parallel development without interfering with the main codebase. When a component was ready for integration, a pull request was opened, providing a structured process for code review before merging. This ensured that all contributions were reviewed by at least one other team member, maintaining code quality and consistency across the project.

While our primary use of GitHub was for integrating individual contributions, this integration-centric workflow inherently supported project management as well. The structured process of branching, reviewing, and merging gave us visibility into progress, enforced accountability, and helped us coordinate efforts across the team. Therefore, GitHub effectively helped us manage the project by providing a clear framework that kept development organized, transparent, and on track. Figure 2.5 represents GitHub repository while figure 2.6 shows branches in GitHub repository.

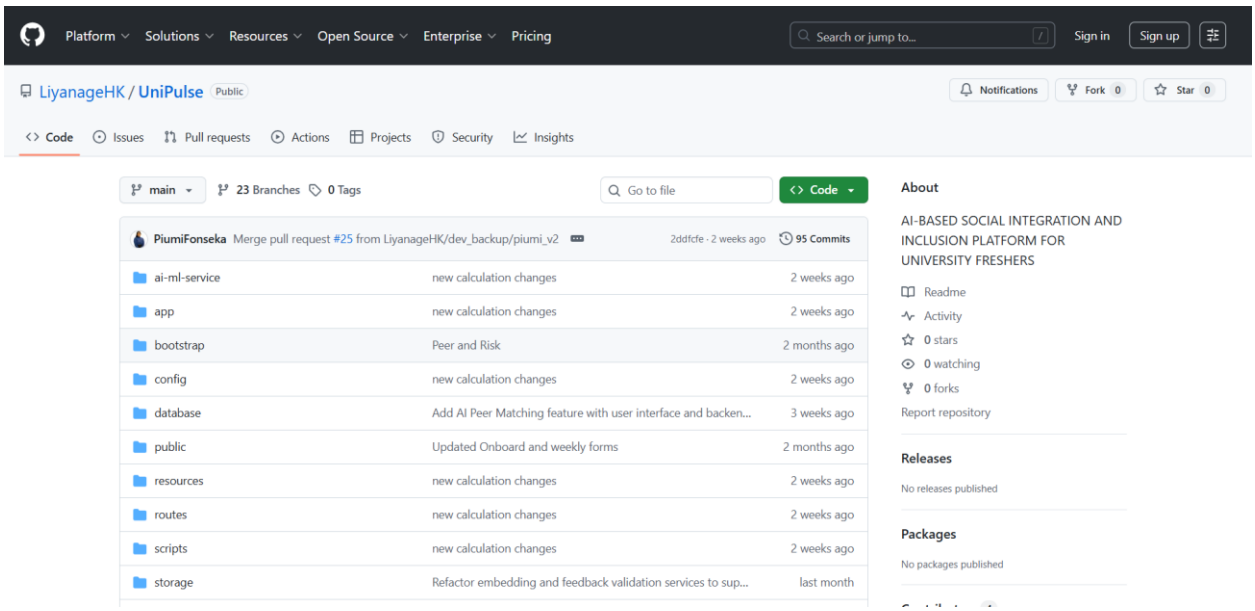

Figure 2.5: GitHub Repository

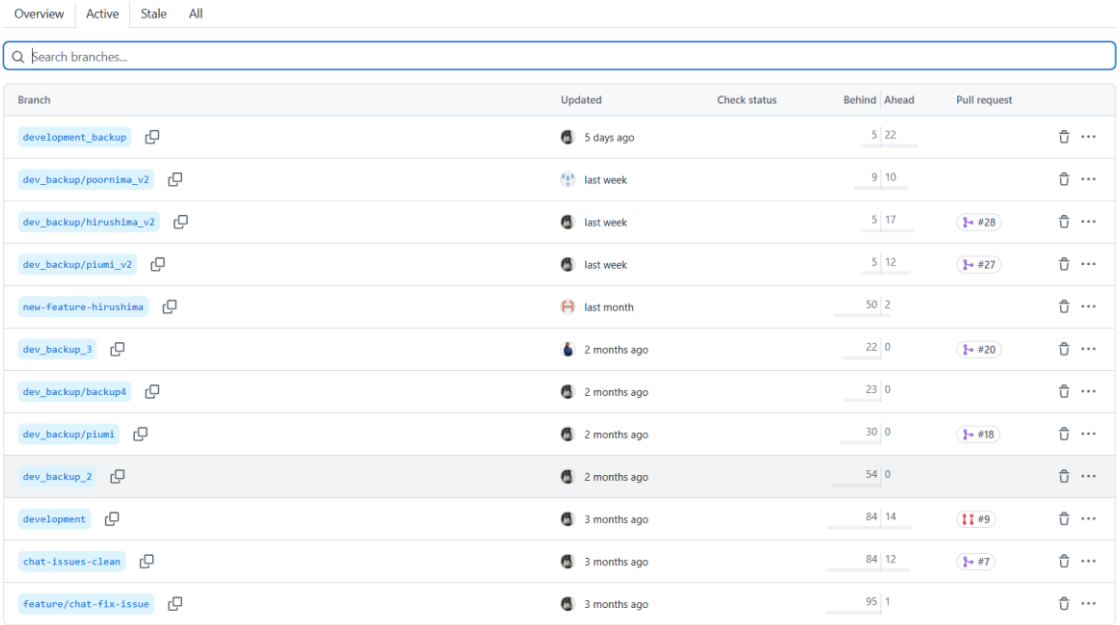

Figure 2.6: Branches in GitHub Repository

2.4 Canva

Canva is a cloud-based graphic design and presentation platform that enables users to create visually compelling content through an intuitive drag-and-drop interface. It offers real-time collaboration features, making it well-suited for team-based design work. In our project, we used Canva as a project management tool specifically for preparing and refining our presentations collaboratively. The platform allowed us to create a shared presentation that all group members could access, edit, and contribute to simultaneously. This eliminated the need for multiple file versions being exchanged via email or messaging apps, which often leads to confusion and version control issues.

By working within a single shared document, each member could add their slides, incorporate feedback, and make real-time adjustments while seeing others' contributions instantly. The commenting feature also facilitated discussion around specific slides, enabling us to refine content efficiently without scheduling separate meetings. This collaborative approach ensured that our final presentation was cohesive, incorporating input from all members seamlessly. As a project management tool, Canva helped us streamline the presentation development process, coordinate contributions effectively, and ensure that our final deliverable reflected the collective effort of the entire group. Figure 2.7 depicts presentation interface in Canva and figure 2.8 shows shared access for presentation editing with the team members.

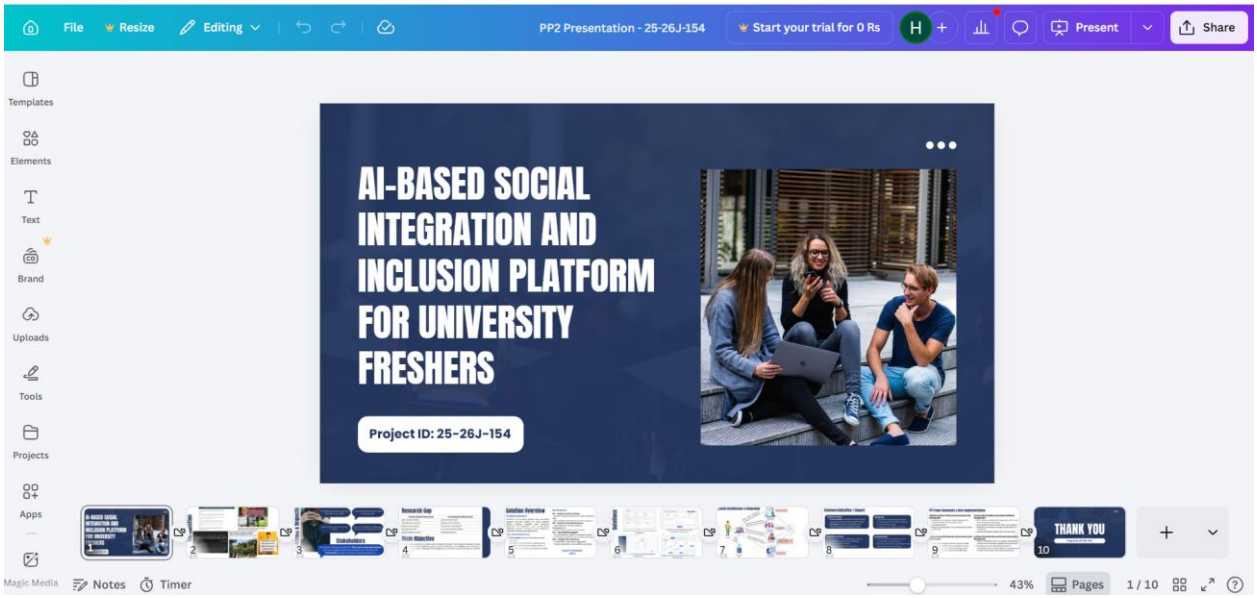

Figure 2.7: Canva Presentation Interface

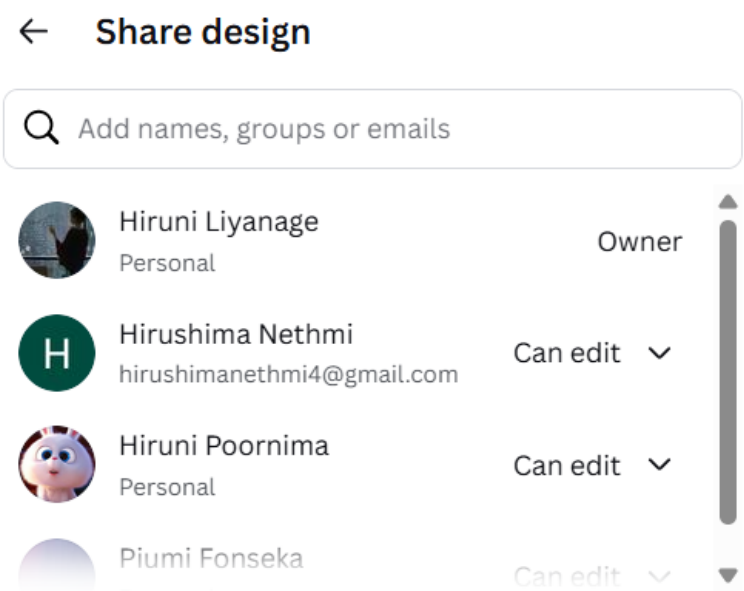

Figure 2.8: Shared Access for Presentation Editing

2.5 WhatsApp Group (Messages & Calls)

For the research project, the WhatsApp group functioned as an effective project management communication tool that facilitated efficient coordination among the four group members. Given the variation in individual schedules and availability, the use of a platform enabling instant and continuous communication was essential. WhatsApp was selected due to its widespread usage, accessibility, and capability to support real-time interaction, making it highly suitable for collaborative work.

Group messaging was utilized to share updates, allocate responsibilities, exchange ideas, and promptly clarify issues. This approach ensured that all members remained informed and aligned with the project objectives, thereby minimizing the risk of miscommunication and missed deadlines. In addition, WhatsApp supported the rapid sharing of resources, including documents, screenshots, links, and voice notes, which enhanced the overall efficiency of communication. The voice call feature proved particularly valuable for conducting detailed discussions and facilitating quick decision-making. Instead of relying solely on formal meetings, quick calls enabled immediate problem resolution, idea generation, and finalization of critical project components. This flexibility contributed to time efficiency and improved productivity.

Furthermore, maintaining all interactions within a particular group provided a centralized record of communication, allowing easy tracking of progress, reference to prior discussions, and reinforcement of accountability among members. Overall, WhatsApp served as a centralized communication hub that strengthened collaboration, enhanced coordination, and supported the smooth execution of tasks, contributing to the successful completion of the research project. Figure 2.9 illustrates the use of WhatsApp group calls to facilitate real-time discussions and decision-making among group members, while Figure 2.10 presents the WhatsApp group chat used for continuous communication, coordination, and information sharing throughout the research project.

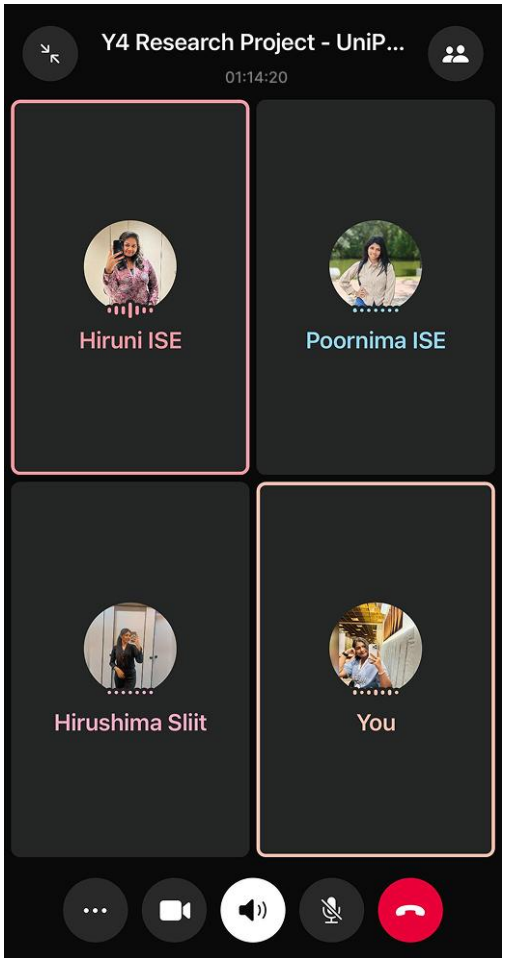

Figure 2.9: Group Call through WhatsApp

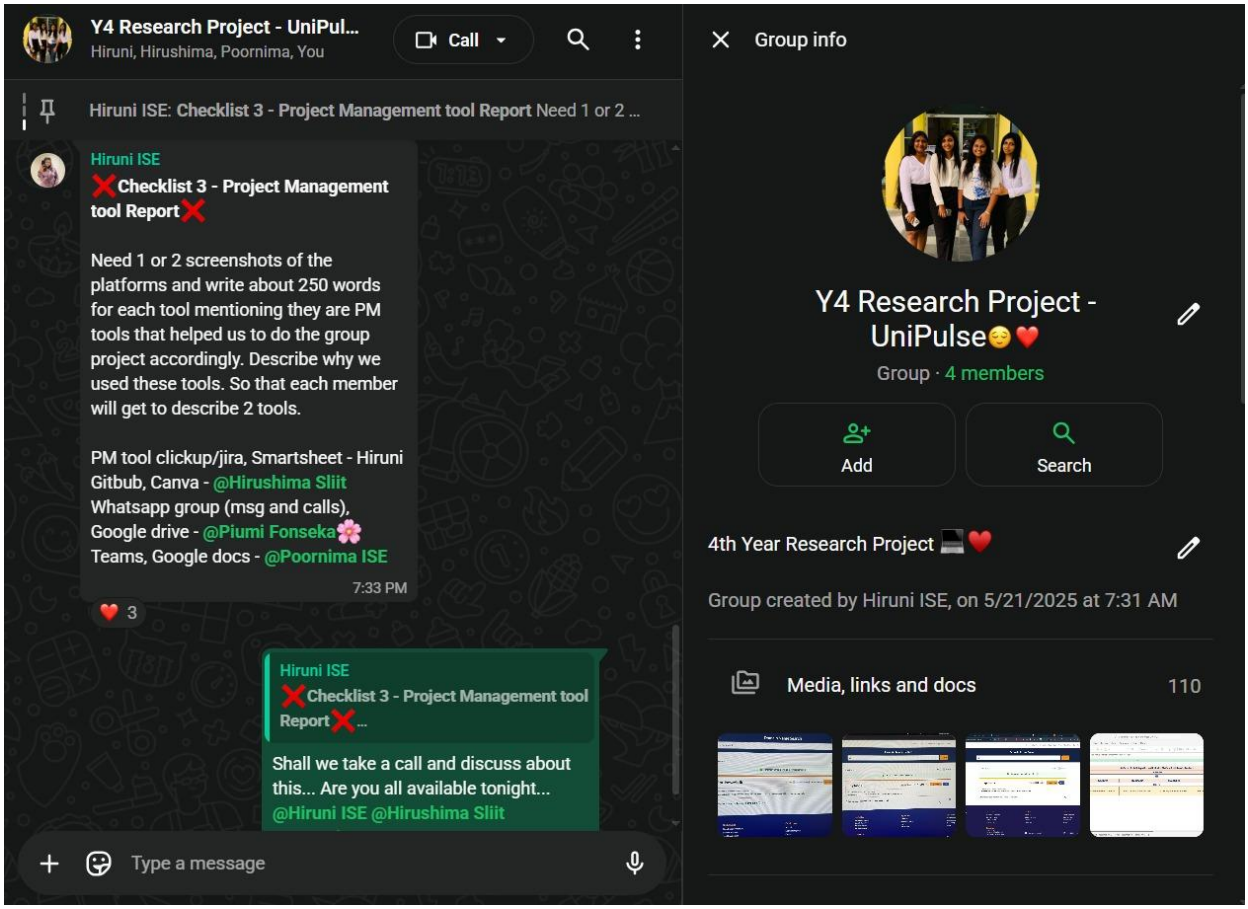

Figure 2.10: WhatsApp Group Chat

2.6 Google Drive

Google Drive served as the primary project management and file-sharing tool, playing a vital role in organizing, storing, and managing all research related documents for the four-member group. As a cloud-based platform, it enabled access to files at any time and from any location, which was particularly beneficial given the varying working environments of the group members. One of the main reasons for selecting Google Drive was its ability to provide a centralized and well-structured storage system, where documents, presentations, and supporting materials could be maintained within shared folders. This ensured that all members had access to the most up-to-date versions of files, thereby minimizing confusion associated with multiple document versions.

The work was systematically organized into specific folders based on assigned tasks, facilitating efficient file management and retrieval. In addition, the real-time collaboration feature allowed multiple users to work simultaneously on the same document, enabling effective division of tasks such as writing, editing, and reviewing content. This significantly enhanced both

productivity and teamwork. Furthermore, the version history feature allowed tracking of changes and restoration of previous versions when necessary, ensuring accuracy and maintaining the overall quality of the research output. Google Drive also improved transparency, as contributions could be monitored by all group members. Overall, it enhanced coordination, streamlined document management, and supported effective collaboration, making it an essential tool in the successful completion of the research project. Figure 2.11 illustrates the use of Google Drive for easy document access.

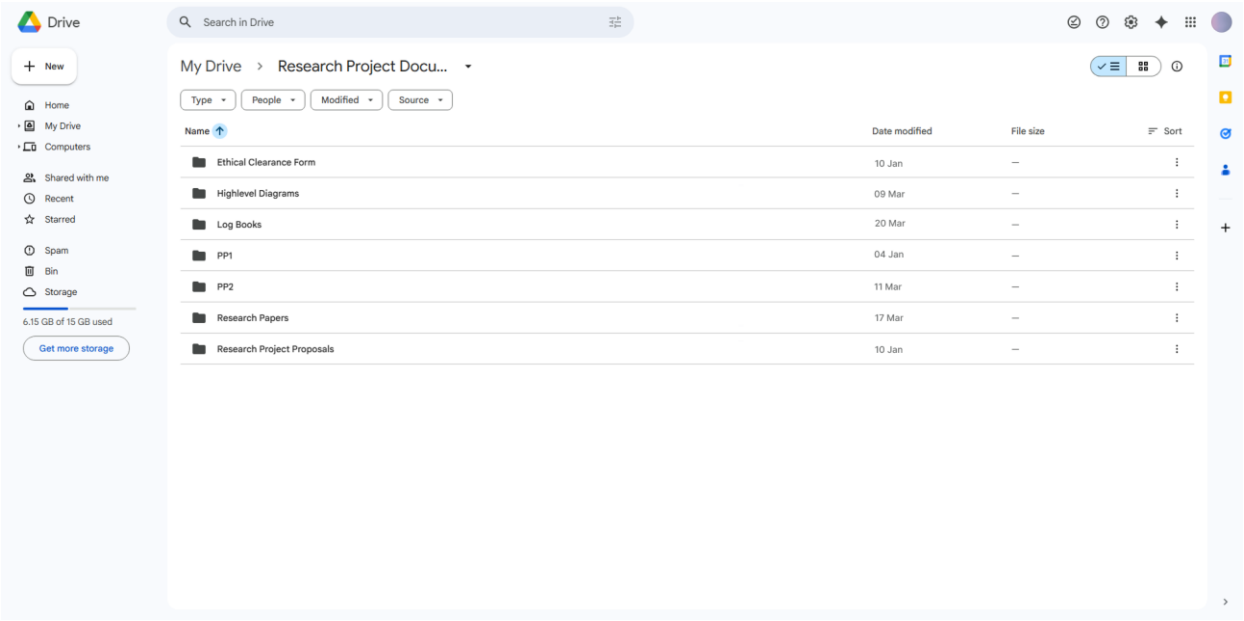

Figure 2.11: Google Drive Access

2.7 Microsoft Teams

Microsoft Teams is a project management and collaboration tool that played a vital role in coordinating our group project activities. It provided a centralized platform for communication, allowing team members to stay connected through chat messages, voice calls, and video meetings. We used Teams primarily to conduct our weekly discussions, clarify doubts, and make collective decisions efficiently.

One of the key reasons for selecting Microsoft Teams was its ability to support real-time communication and scheduled meetings. This was especially important since our group members had different schedules due to academic and internship commitments. The meeting feature enabled us to share screens, present progress, and discuss project updates effectively, ensuring everyone stayed aligned with the project goals.

Additionally, Teams allowed us to organize conversations into channels, making it easier to manage various aspects of the project such as planning, development, and documentation. The file-sharing capability also helped us quickly exchange resources and keep all important files accessible in one place.

Overall, Microsoft Teams significantly improved our team coordination, communication efficiency, and decision-making process. It ensured that all members remained engaged and informed throughout the project lifecycle, contributing to the successful completion of our group work. Figure 2.12 shows the Microsoft Teams meeting window.

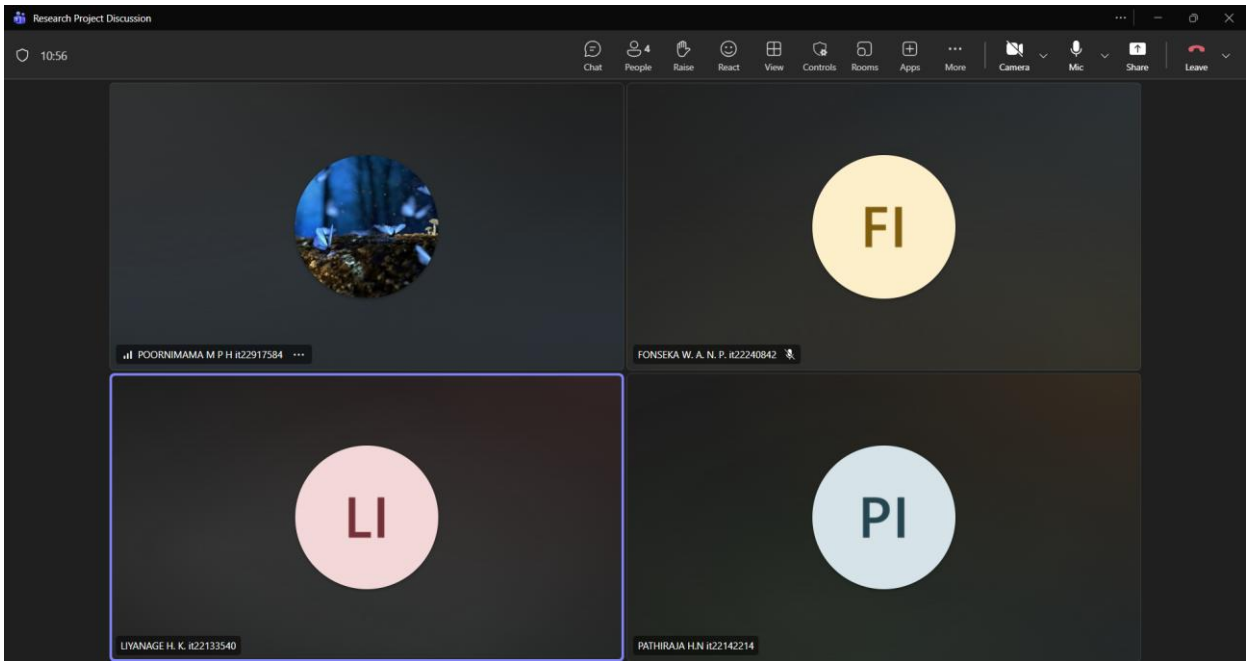

Figure 2.12: Microsoft Teams Meeting

2.8 Google Docs

Google Docs is a cloud-based document management and collaboration tool that we used extensively for preparing and editing our project documentation. It allowed multiple team members to work on the same document simultaneously, making it highly effective for collaborative writing tasks. We chose Google Docs mainly because of its real-time editing and auto-saving features. These features ensured that no work was lost and that all updates were instantly visible to every team member. This reduced confusion and eliminated the need for maintaining multiple versions of the same document. Another important advantage of Google Docs is its commenting and suggestion features. These tools enabled team members to provide

feedback, suggest improvements, and make corrections without directly altering the original content. This helped us maintain the quality and consistency of our reports. Furthermore, since Google Docs is cloud-based, it provides easy access from any device with an internet connection. This flexibility allowed team members to contribute to the project anytime and from anywhere.

In conclusion, Google Docs enhanced our documentation process by improving collaboration, efficiency, and accuracy. It ensured smooth teamwork and played a key role in completing our project reports successfully. Figure 2.13 shows project report editing through Google Docs and figure 2.14 shows Google Doc access with the group members.

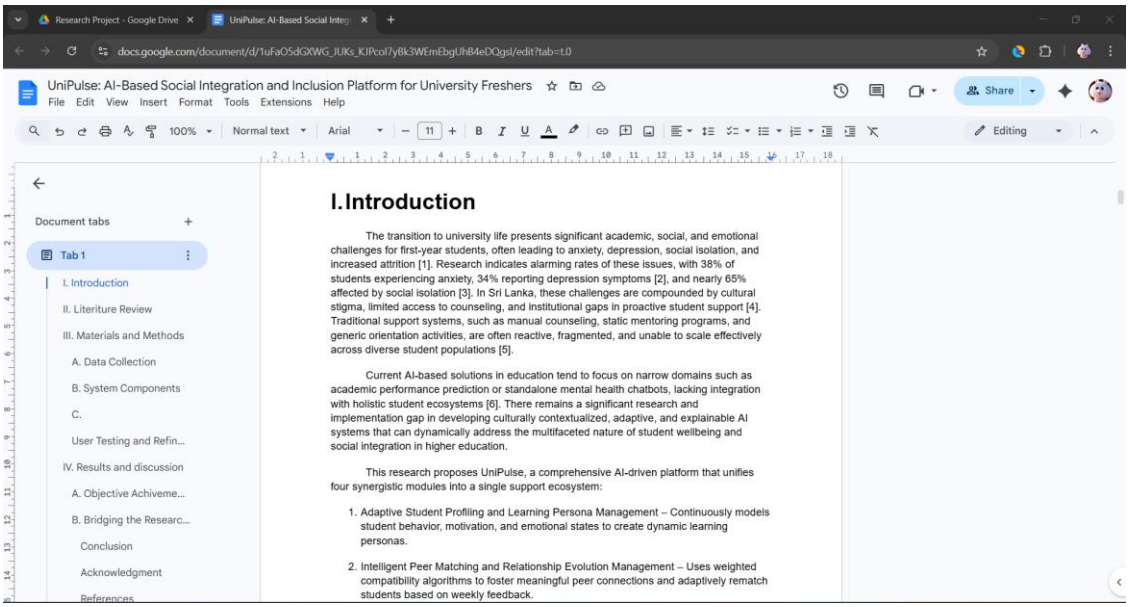

Figure 2.13: Project Report Editing through Google Docs

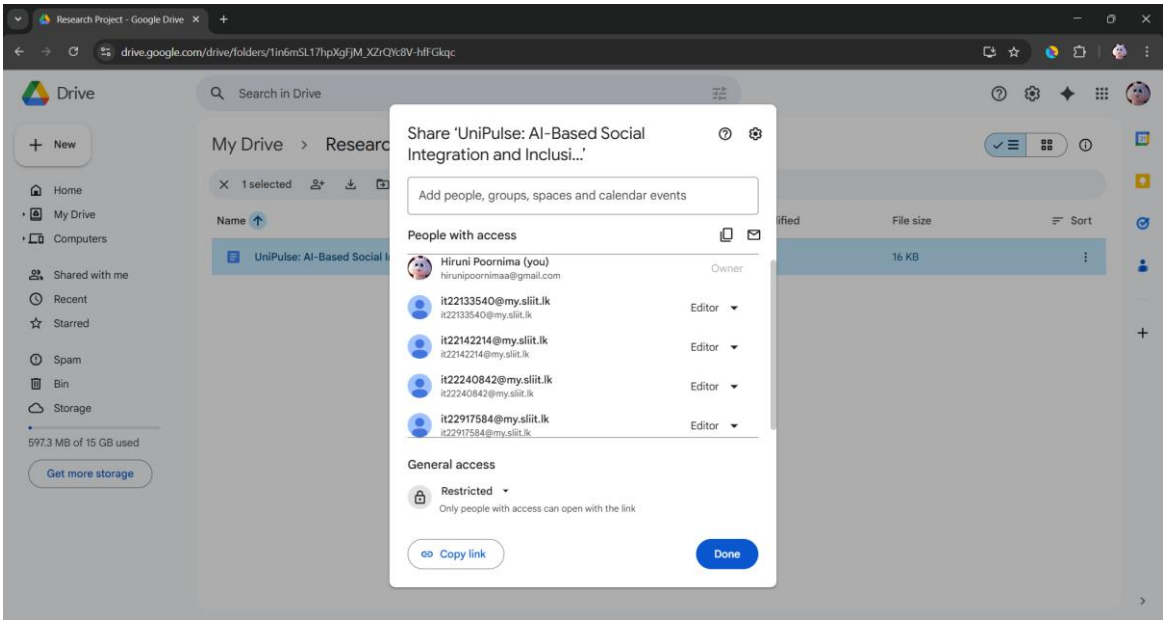

Figure 2.14: Google Doc Access

3. Conclusion

The successful execution of the "AI-Based Social Integration and Inclusion Platform for University Freshers" project was facilitated by the strategic use of multiple project management and collaboration tools. ClickUp and Smartsheet provided structured task management and timeline visualization, ensuring accountability, clarity, and efficient scheduling. GitHub and Canva enabled collaborative development and content creation, while Google Drive, Google Docs, WhatsApp, and Microsoft Teams strengthened real-time communication, document sharing, and team coordination.

The integration of these tools created a seamless workflow, enhanced transparency, and improved overall productivity. Each team member could contribute effectively, track progress, and access updated resources without delays, minimizing miscommunication and duplication of work. The adoption of these tools not only supported the technical and organizational aspects of the project but also fostered stronger collaboration, effective decision-making, and timely completion of deliverables.

The experience demonstrates that combining task management, communication, and collaborative platforms is essential for managing complex academic projects, highlighting the importance of leveraging technology to enhance teamwork and achieve project goals efficiently.